

Dear bestie,

How can I thank you
for being in my life?

For those unladylike laughter sessions.

For those long, tight, it-will-be alright hugs.

For telling me to dump that loser!

For hyping me by saying, 'You got this'.

Bestie, how can I thank you
for the khichdi you send
when I'm sick.

For spoiling my 5-year-old
like she's yours

For healing me with love and memes.

For growing old with me.

The truth is, there are no words.

Just an infinite amount of gratitude.

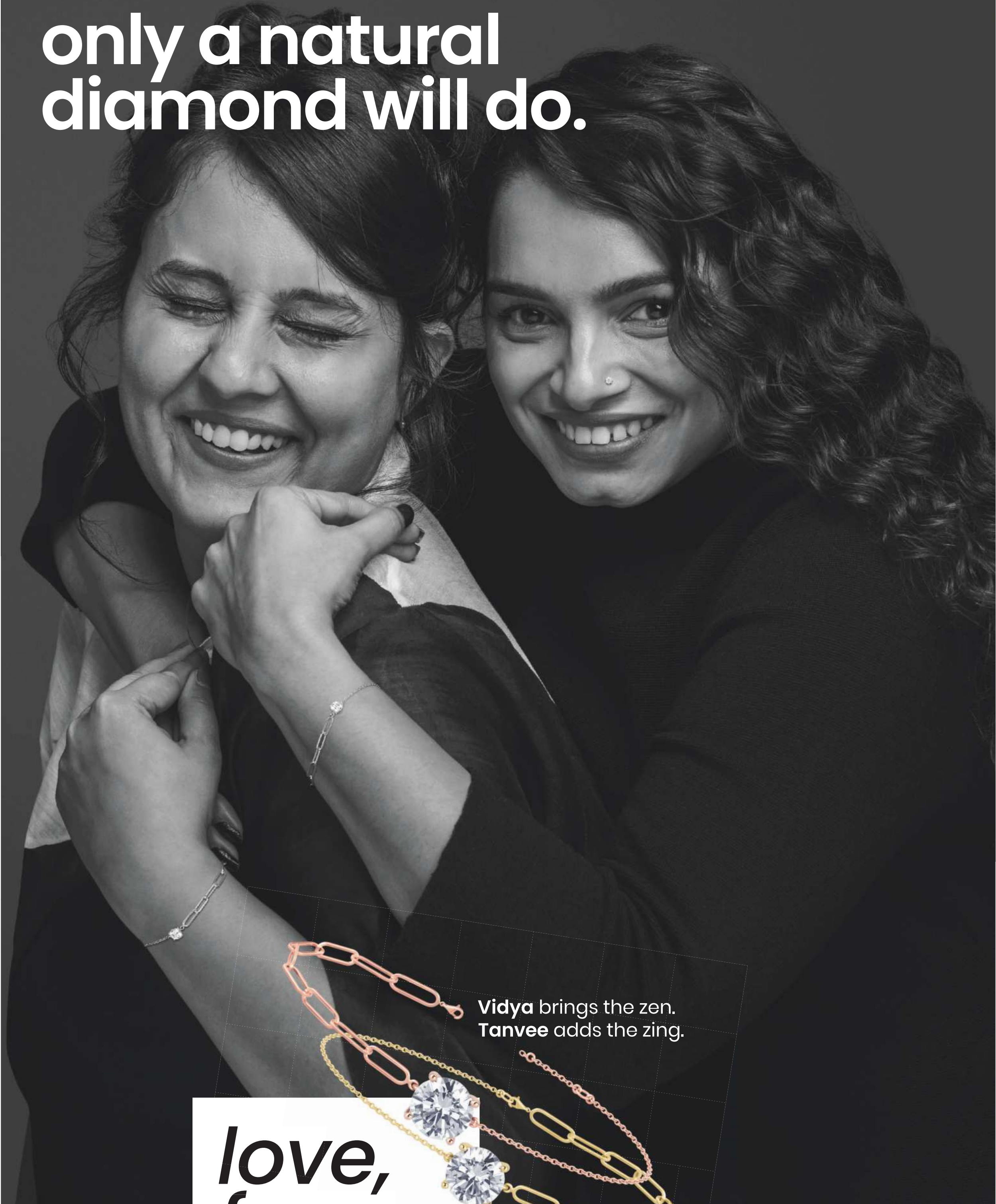
For being my partner-in-shine.

my fill-in-the-blank, my natural fit.

They say the truest friendships cannot be manufactured,
they simply unfold naturally.

How true that is for us, bestie.

Love so natural
only a natural
diamond will do.



Vidya brings the zen.
Tanvee adds the zing.

*love,
from
bestie*
BRACELET
COLLECTION



DE BEERS GROUP
A DIAMOND IS FOREVER



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THE HINDU



Art-hop across Chennai's galleries, now stacked with the best contemporary artists **P2**

MEET LITHANYA, POPULAR CHILD ARTISTE **P4**

From Nambi Narayanan to GD Naidu: Why actor Madhavan is drawn to unsung Indian heroes

Extraordinary ordinary men



Beyond the spotlight
Madhavan; (inset) the actor in his upcoming film *G.D.N.*, a biopic on inventor GD Naidu.
THAMODHARAN B

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Unsung heroes make for great cinema. And Madhavan knows that a little too well.

A few years ago, he came up with *Rocketry: The Nambi Effect*, which told the story of one such hero – Nambi Narayanan, former scientist and aerospace engineer at the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). In fact, circumstances forced the actor to turn filmmaker to ensure

that his passion project made it to the big screen. His latest obsession is another such unsung hero: inventor and industrial pioneer, GD Naidu. “I love watching and hearing about the extraordinary achievements of ordinary men,” the 56-year-old actor says, as he looks out of his room in a luxury hotel in Chennai, with a bird’s eye view of bustling city roads below.

Forgotten genius
Maddy – as he is called, by both friends and fans – is fascinated by the life and times of Gopalsamy Doraisamy

Naidu. “There are great achievers in every field, but the people I find most fascinating are the ones who do what they do without any expectation of recognition during their lifetime. Nambi Narayan did that. GD Naidu was also one such extraordinary individual.”

Directed by Krishnakumar Ramkumar and produced by Varghese Moolan Pictures, *G.D.N.* – set to release on August 7 – will unveil the genius of GD Naidu, widely regarded as the ‘Edison of India’. In fact, upon his passing in 1974, former Tamil

Nadu Chief Minister CN Annadurai remarked, “Our society did not make use of GD Naidu’s intellect. His inventions are a very valuable resource to society.”

Lifting the veil
Annadurai must have been referring to his inventions such as the vote recording machine, radio clock and the electric razor, among others, but all these will only form a part of Madhavan’s current biopic on the man. “All that has been written and known about him is a fraction of what he was. What he has done for

Coimbatore, India and society is unsung, all hidden behind the fact that the media and the British portrayed him in a certain manner and therefore relegated him to a corner of the history book. In fact, the fight in this film is to make his story a part of the syllabus, at least in Tamil Nadu,” he states, adding, “What Uber or Bill Gates has done today is what GD Naidu thought of many decades ago.”

Sporting a bald, powerful look with thick glasses in one of the posters, Madhavan’s transformation for *G.D.N.* might take some by surprise or even shock. The portions where he had to play the older version of Naidu involved over three hours of make-up. “He wore very thick-set glasses. To wear that and do those sequences was tough because I could barely see. If you have to walk with it, it becomes more difficult. So, I had to map it in my mind and walk, without bumping into furniture. To keep all that in mind and know that I have to come across as somebody real was a test.”

Revisiting *Run*
Madhavan is juggling multiple projects and taking his craft seriously today. But way back in the early 2000s, he was

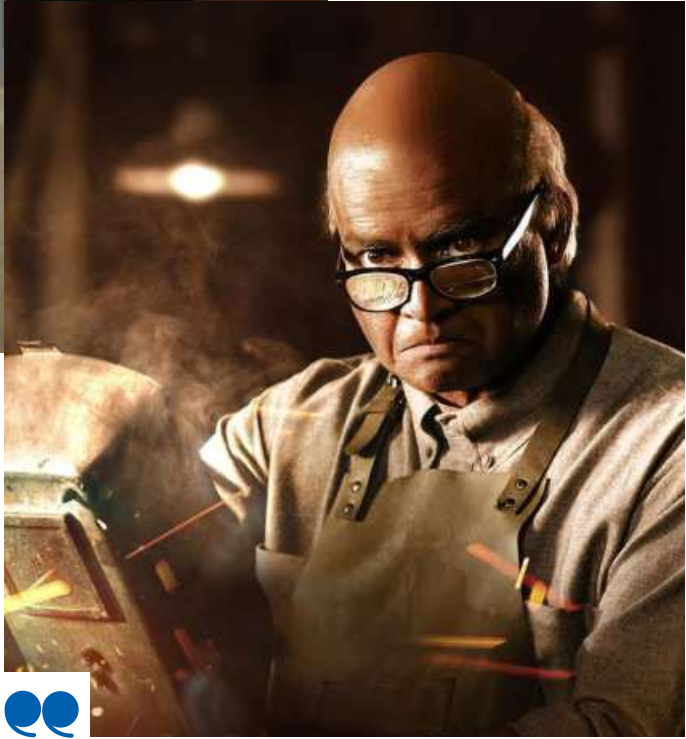
described as the chocolate boy when he burst into Tamil films with Mani Ratnam’s *Alaipayuthe*, a debut that he looks back today with a lot of gratitude. If films like *Alaipayuthe* and *Minnale* gave him a big launchpad, action film *Run* (2002) – which recently re-released in theatres – showed him in a different light. “It was a turning point in my career,” he points out, “After having played lover-boy roles, no one expected me to wallow the bad guys.”

Run features an iconic shutter fight sequence, where Madhavan seemingly runs away from the baddies, only to close the shutters of a subway and then take them on, in a moment that Tamil film audiences continue to celebrate till today. “I said yes to the film for that one sequence.”

He does not intentionally re-watch his earlier work – unless they come on when he switches channels on the TV or they surface while sifting through OTT platforms – but when he does, Maddy always believes he could have done things better. “In *Aayutha Ezhuthu*, I wish I had worked more on my accent to make it sound like a guy from that background. I wish my Tamil was better in *Kannathil Muthamittal*. There is always a hardened critic inside me looking at my work and feeling that it was not enough. It is probably the predominant feeling of every actor who is married to his job,” he says.

Even as Madhavan keenly awaits the response to *G.D.N.*, he is looking forward to working on more stories that he can relate to. Up next, is Netflix OTT series *Legacy* and a film titled *Circle* with Kangana Ranaut that has been directed by Vijay. There is also a film titled *Bridge* with filmmaker Nidhi. “I know my limitations, but I also know what makes me tick. I know what my life experiences can support in terms of the character I chose to play. It could be comedy, or the defence sector, or sport, or even teaching... which have all been part of my life experiences. I look for stories that I relate to, bite deeply into it and live with it for months.”

G.D.N. is releasing on August 7.



Chennai is a world of its own. For me, it is a sort of escape from the rest of the world. I love my time here and cherish spending a quiet evening with old friends

MADHAVAN

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Correct answer Previous edition of the Zifo Open Quiz. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

What is the fourth letter of the Greek alphabet? Who was the last Tsar of Russia? Which is the only sea without any coastlines?

If you go into this quiz expecting such questions, it might be time to read up a little further for Chennai’s iconic Landmark Quiz on August 15.

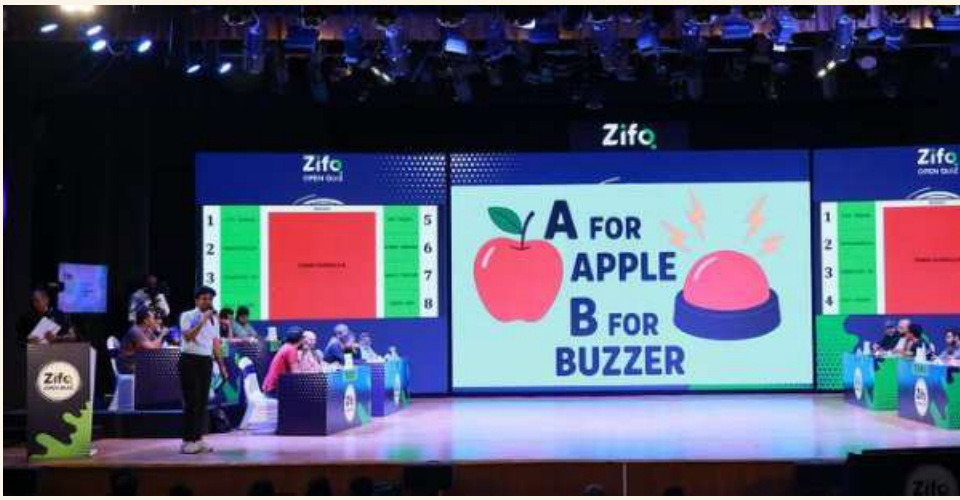
Now in its 33rd year, the quiz has become as much an Independence Day tradition as the flag-hoisting ceremonies that unfold across the country. Every year, hundreds of teams, from seasoned quizzers to first-timers, school students to families, gather (this time at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall), armed with little more than curiosity and a love for cracking a question.

What began as the Landmark Quiz in 1994 has grown into one of India’s largest open general knowledge quizzes, drawing participants from across the country and occasionally, overseas. Today, under the banner of the Zifo Open Quiz, it continues to prove that in Chennai, curiosity is still a spectator sport.

“There is a culture of curiosity and knowledge-seeking in Chennai that isn’t found anywhere else. Maybe Kolkata comes close, but even there the numbers don’t compare,” says Dr Navin Jayakumar, quizmaster, Zifo Open Quiz, adding that a few years ago, the quiz received registrations for over 1,000 teams and this year it has crossed 400 already.

The quiz’s longevity, however, has as much to do with the community that has rallied behind it as the questions themselves. For nearly 25 years, it was backed by Landmark and its founder Hemu Ramaiah, who, Dr Navin says, still turns up every year to help mark the answer sheets. When the bookstore chain shut down after the pandemic, he was determined to keep the tradition alive.

“I was not willing to let go of the date August 15. In 2021, even with all the lockdown restrictions, I conducted the quiz online because I wanted to commemorate it in some way. In 2022, I borrowed money from friends and organised the quiz myself. I didn’t want to let go of the tradition even without a sponsor,”



On the buzzer

Chennai’s iconic Zifo Open Quiz returns this Independence Day, bringing with it 33 years of trivia, tradition, and fierce competition

he says adding that Raj Prakash G, founder of Zifo came into the picture in 2021. “He told me, ‘We used to come and enjoy the quiz. We don’t want this to die.’ The people who once took part in the quiz are now sponsoring it,” says Dr Navin.

This year’s edition promises a few new additions as well. While the questions will continue to span history, current affairs, science and popular culture, Dr Navin says the quiz has evolved with its audience. “I’m getting older. I started this when I was 30 and now I’m 64.

There’s a lot of pop culture that younger people know and I don’t. That’s why, for the past three years, Siddhanth Rao has been the co-quizmaster. The quiz is now more youth-oriented because young people are the future of the quiz.” He also hints at a surprise for this

On August 22, 1639, the transaction that laid the foundation for the city of Madras was signed, a date now celebrated every year as Madras Day. This month our reporters will be celebrating the city with stories that explore Chennai’s history, food, people and neighbourhoods. Want to know your home better? Watch this space.



year’s audience. Unlike previous editions, spectators will not just be watching from the sidelines. “We’re going to allow people to pull out their phones, but only after the preliminary round is over. They will be able to actively take part in the quiz till the very end, and we’ll have prizes for them too,” he says with enthusiasm.

And for those planning to take part, Dr Navin has one piece of advice: don’t prepare for the quiz. “Just be curious. Read the newspaper every day, but don’t stop at the headlines. If you read about the Strait of Hormuz, go and find out where it is, its history and the countries around it. Read what interests you and stay curious,” he says.

The Zifo Open Quiz is not an exam. “The joy lies in discovering something new and saying, ‘I didn’t know that. That’s fascinating.’ Above all, come with your friends and family and have a good time. The community is what keeps this quiz alive.”

The Zifo Open Quiz 2025 will be held on August 15, 1.15pm, at the Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall. For details and registration look up zifoopenquiz.com.



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Art is not always something you stand quietly in front of. Sometimes, it spills into a cafe conversation, a studio visit, or even an entire city. This August, Chennai becomes a large gallery as Contemporary Now returns for its third edition, transforming museums, galleries, and cultural spaces, inviting visitors to wander, question, linger, and discover not just art, but the city itself.

The third edition brings together 66 artists from seven leading galleries, complemented by a city-wide programme of exhibitions, discussions, artist walkthroughs and workshops.

Running from August 8 to 25, **Contemporary Now will be anchored at the Lalit Kala Akademi**, with a series of partner programmes unfolding across Chennai. Work will be presented by seven leading galleries – Ashvita’s, Chemould Prescott Road, Chatterjee & Lal, Experimenter, Project 88, TARQ and Vadehra Art Gallery. This year’s edition is centred on the curatorial theme Practices in Continuum: Tracing the Present, exploring how contemporary artistic practices evolve through research, experimentation and dialogue.

Serving as the main hub of Contemporary Now, Lalit Kala Akademi brings together works

A city in conversation

From August 8 to 25, **Contemporary Now transforms Chennai** into a city-wide gallery, bringing together 66 artists, seven leading galleries, exhibitions, talks, workshops and artist walkthroughs across museums and cultural spaces

ranging from charcoal on fabric to recycled teak wood, hand-spun textiles, digital video, and photography; the exhibition showcases artists working across a range of materials and mediums. Among the highlights are works by Anju Dodiya, Jitish Kallat, Mithu Sen, Nikhil Chopra, Raghava KK, Thukral and Tagra, Manas Udayakumar and more, each bringing their own visual vocabulary to a show that invites viewers to slow down, look closely and engage with their stories.

Ashvita’s on Radha Krishnan Salai hosts **Continuiverse** by C Krishnaswamy inviting viewers to reflect on our relationship with land, memory, and community through a series of sculptures. Meanwhile, at Ashvita’s Flagship,

the gallery’s new Chennai space, Benitha K Perciyal presents **How Long Will We Live? Or When Will We Die?** – an exhibition that pairs her artworks with the books, research, and objects that have shaped her artistic practice and way of seeing.

“Contemporary Now is built around the collector. Buying art isn’t an impulse purchase; you’re asking someone to invest anywhere between ₹5 lakh and ₹15 lakh in a work. So our job is to give them confidence. We have brought together the best galleries and artists, and every artwork sold through Contemporary Now comes with a year of art insurance, along with digital authentication and registration. We want collecting art to feel as secure and transparent as

any other serious investment,” says Ashvin E Rajagopalan, director, Ashvita’s and Contemporary Now.

Madras Abstraction, presented by Gallery Veda as part of Contemporary Now, traces the evolution of abstraction through the lens of the Madras Art Movement that started in the 1960s, pioneered by DP Roy Chowdhury and KCS Paniker. Bringing together works by eight artists across generations: KV Haridasan, Achuthan Kudallur, Akkitham Narayanan, Velu Vishwanadhan, Ganesh Selvaraj, Saravanan Parasuraman, Suresh Kumar, and Yuvan Bothysathuvar, the exhibition explores how a distinctly South Indian visual language emerged from the intersection of regional history,



Art odyssey
(Clockwise from far left) Artwork by artists Saju Kunhan; G Gurunathan; Anju Dodiya; Dhruvi Acharya; and a sculpture by the Chanakya School.



spirituality and modernist thought. For the event, the artists reinterpret abstraction through themes of geometry, colour, memory, and philosophy, highlighting the legacy of this influential art movement.

Alongside the exhibitions, Contemporary Now will also feature a line-up of talks and partner programmes. On August 8 at 5pm, Ashvita’s Flagship will host **The Many Lives of the Photobook: A Contemporary Lens to Publishing Practices & Shared Futures**, a



panel discussion with Brendan Embser, Balaji Maheshwar and Indu Antony, moderated by Shuchi Kapoor, exploring the evolving role of the photobook. Later that evening, at 7pm, Raw Mango, Teynampet, hosts **On Patronage: Public Impact, Private Collections**, with Anu Menda, Meha Patel, Jaiveer Johal and Siddharth Somaiya in conversation with Umah Jacob on the relationship between private collections and public culture.

Then there is **I Have A Dream**, a studio exhibition by George K, at the George K Studio, T Nagar. Presented by Apparao Galleries and curated by Jaiveer Johal, this partner programme offers a peek into the artist’s visual language in the space where he created most of his art.

For those interested in photography, **In Dialogue with Nature**, presented by the Chennai Photo Biennale Foundation and WWF-India, runs from August 8 to 22, at the Avtar Foundation for the Arts, bringing together limited-edition photographs and portfolios centred on ecology, conservation and the natural world. Also opening on August 8 is **Unruly Bodies: Sighting the Body Politic** from the Avtar Collection, curated by Suchitra Vijayan at Espace 24, Alliance Française of Madras. The exhibition examines how power shapes bodies, memory, identity and belonging through works from the Avtar Collection.

Over the next two weeks, the city becomes a map of conversations and discoveries, reminding us that art lives not just within white walls, but in the people, places and stories that shape a city.

Contemporary Now Edition-III starts from August 8. For the full schedule, follow @contemporarynow on Instagram.



Notes on love

Celebrating the launch of her first independent album *Love Language*, singer Susha hosts an intimate evening of music which invites listeners to revel in jazz, poetry, songs in English and Tamil, the texture of strings, independent and original music. The evening features Sayee Rakshith on the violin, Rithu Vysakh on the cello and Laxman Arvind on the double bass. @Medai, Alwarpet, today at 7pm. Tickets on kynhood.com



The living fence

Around two lakes in Coimbatore, bamboo is taking root acting as a barrier that promises cleaner water, richer biodiversity and healthier ecosystems

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At the 90-acre Vellalore Lake butterflies bask in sunshine, ducks glide along the still waters, while pelicans stretch their wing. Along the bund, rows of tall, slender, and woody bamboo stalks sway, standing guard to this fragile ecosystem.

A thriving bamboo fence project has been launched at two prominent water bodies in the city, the 20-acre Kolarampathy that surrounds the iconic Perur temple like a necklace and the picturesque 90-acre Vellalore Lake, home to the city’s first butterfly park. The natural barrier aims to protect the tanks from encroachments and dumping of waste while reviving the bio-diversity of the lake.

“Why not bamboo?” asks R Manikandan of Kovai Kulangal Padhukaapu Amaippu that restores neglected water bodies in Coimbatore. The NGO has implemented the project along with the support of the district administration and CSR initiative of

JDFS Business Solutions LLP. “While tall palmyra trees lining lakes is a familiar sight even now, bamboo has completely disappeared. We are bringing it back,” he says adding that the choice is backed by research.

“The bamboo root system grows into a dense ‘mat’ of fine roots which is shallow but wide spread. This means that its ability to hold soil together along fragile river banks (where erosion is possible) is excellent. A mature bamboo plant generates a higher output of oxygen. The green barrier discourages encroachments and illegal dumping of wastes while restoring bio-diversity by building a habitat for birds, rodents and other wildlife,” explains Manikandan.

During the first phase, over 300 bamboo saplings of as many as 16 bamboo species including Burmese bamboo, giant bamboo, Taiwan giant bamboo, Travancore reed, Buddha belly, yellow bamboo and more have been planted along the

Nature’s best defence (Clockwise from left) A unique bamboo belt fencing the Vellalore Lake in Coimbatore; a three-storey bamboo house in Meppadi, Wayanad; and bird life in Coimbatore wetlands. PERIASAMY M AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



lakes. “All the 16 species are highly effective in soil conservation, as they are clumping bamboos that grow close to each other featuring short root systems that expand slowly in tight clusters. It serves as living net under the soil and holds the earth together,” explains Kannan CS Warrior, director, Kerala Forest Research Institute in Thrissur, which is home to Asia’s largest bamboos with 72 species.

M Baburaj, an environmentalist who lives in a three-storey ‘bamboo house’ in Meppadi, Wayanad says it has also emerged as a “magic material” for construction and interior design. Baburaj is director, World of Bamboo, a craft village in Wayanad and has been promoting bamboo for the past three decades.

“Besides conservation, it’s time to look at eco-friendly industrial applications. Bamboo can serve as raw material in as many as 10 industries including sustainable architecture, lumbering, furniture, bioplastic making, ethanol

production, bamboo fibre to name a few. We haven’t been able to develop the bamboo industry and tap its potential in areas such as architecture,” he says, drawing attention to bamboo biochar, which effectively improves the carbon content of soil by adding stable fixed carbon, boosting soil organic matter, and driving long-term carbon sequestration.

D Saravanan, an environmentalist who transformed 100 acres of barren wasteland in Poothurai village, near Villupuram district and Pudukcherry into the lush Aranya Forest and Sanctuary over a period of nearly 30 years says that the material, “Often referred to as ‘green gold’ and ‘poor man’s timber’, can replace wood in many applications.”

He adds, “It is the fastest growing biomass, reaching up to three feet daily. It can be harvested in three to five years and thrives in a wide range of environments.” Saravanan also explains how bamboo regulates oxygen and carbon dioxide in the atmosphere: “A hectare of bamboo plantation absorbs 17 tonnes of carbon in one year. Each bamboo plant absorbs 3.5 kilograms of carbon.”

Dense forest canopies

Kannan picks the Taiwan giant bamboo as the most versatile and economically viable species while the Travancore reed is a key, endemic species of the Western Ghats that serves as a bio-diversity corridor. “Giant bamboo varieties form towering groves creating dense forest canopies. Others like multiplex or green bamboo, bush bamboo and needle bamboo build the under-story of forest, a perfect foraging ground for reptiles and rodents,” he says.

The restoration plan in Coimbatore includes clearing invasive vegetation and shrubs along a thousand-foot stretch of the tank bund, installing a 1,150-foot GT diamond mesh fence for protection, and providing drip irrigation. Manikandan says the project is expected to stabilise the tank bund, improve biodiversity, and provide shelter for birds and small animals.

As it turns out, one of the most effective ways to protect a lake is to let Nature do most of the work.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #65
(Set by Doppelganger)

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Across
1 Rage (4)
3 Landmass in Western Hemisphere (8)
9 Opposite of smoothen (7)
10 Bid farewell (5)
11 Come in (5)
12 Frolic (6)
14 Not sharp (6)
16 Neaten (4,2)
19 Strong fear (6)
21 Straightforward (5)
24 Mistake (5)
25 Can opener (4,3)
26 Amorphous (8)
27 Footwear (4)

Down
1 Frill on garment (8)
2 Climb up (5)
4 Administer (6)
5 Kingdom (5)
6 Coffee additive (7)
7 Male stallion (4)
8 Refrain (6)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Solution No. 65

Q	O	H	S		Q	E	J	V	H	S	N	
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All is quiet in this tree-lined neighbourhood except for the pounding from a drum kit that seems to come from deep within a studio. I knock on the door, hoping to be let in. No one answers. The five men inside are busy with The Scorpions.

The iconic German band founded 61 years ago still seems to cast a spell – the men in the studio are rehearsing ‘Rock You Like A Hurricane’, a signature song from The Scorpions album *Love At First Sting* from that great era of rock, the 1980s. A heavy guitar riff from a Yamaha Revstar and an Ibanez Five String anchors the song, there is a soaring sing-along chorus and the lyrics are peppered with deep desire. When the last note bounces off the walls, the men who are part of the Madras Rock Collective (MRC), turn around and shout out their hellos.

The MRC, comprising seasoned musicians, is a young band that plays old music. “We had our first gig only in April this year,” says bass guitarist Mario Nambiar. “All of us play with other bands too and we’ve been around for at least two decades. The idea to form this band came up in 2018, when we thought we should form one

Love at first string

The Madras Rock Collective’s concert will feature timeless rock anthems this Friday



instead of getting together just to play tribute pieces. But it took its time coming.”

Drummer Rahul Gopal, a BITS Pilani graduate who found his calling in rock while hanging out with seniors in college, and has since been part of bands such as Little Babushkas Grind, says, “It was only last year that we thought of a name for the band. And ballads and hard rock from the 1980s-2000s is where we are at.”

If one was thinking that the sounds of rock music from the ‘80s was fading in the city, Aakash Jacob’s guttural vocals would tell you otherwise. His voice underlines the rebellion that rock music set out to speak for, something he learnt early on in his days at Madras Christian College. “Mario and I were at a concert together once and thought we should speak to Rahul, Vivin and Josh and explore if this

Yesterday once more (From left) Rahul Gopal, Mario Nambiar, Vivin Kuruvilla, Josh Mark Raj and Aakash Jacob of the Madras Rock Collective; (below) the band at practice. B VELANKANNI RAJ

was what we wanted to do together. It happened rather organically,” says Aakash, a banker and frontman for Rusty Moe. Vivin Kuruvilla, keyboardist, founding member of the metal band Blood and Iron, who works in sales and marketing, plays the opening chords of Van Halen’s ‘Right Now’ on his Korg Nautilus. Vivin did the whole Trinity College of Music exam grind for the keyboard starting while still in school. ‘Right Now’ is also the favourite of guitarist Josh Mark Raj, an award-winning musician and teacher who has worked with AR Rahman, among others. He says, “I’m often in recording sessions and rarely do I get to play music like Van Halen’s, music that I’m passionate about.”

Rahul, a self-taught drummer who is now a nutrition coach with a new-found love for pistol shooting, says twirling his Vater drumsticks, “We stick to classic English rock because it lends raw energy to the stage, to the evening.”

Mario who also walks the fine line between the corporate world and his alternate life as a musician says he was gob-smacked by the guitar when he first heard it at Loyola College’s culturals, Ovations. He learnt the instrument from scratch, going from acoustic to bass guitar, along the way being part of the famous band Nerve Wreck. “We have four gigs lined up over the next few months, including one in Bangalore on August 22 and one at Hard Rock here,” he says.

In Chennai, the band will play anthems by Whitesnake, Def Leppard, Deep Purple, Toto, Journey, Mr Big, Extreme, The Scorpions and the odd song from Bryan Adams and Bon Jovi.

As I leave, there is friendly banter about which is their favourite – the votes are split between ‘Cupid’s Dead’ by Extreme and Van Halen’s ‘Right Now’. I’d choose the latter; as the lyrics suggest “*catch that magic moment*” this Friday.

The Madras Rock Collective will perform on August 7, 8.45pm onwards, at Bay 146, The Savera Hotel, RK Salai. Entry for ages 21 and above. Tickets priced ₹250 onwards on district.in with a ₹750 cover charge that is redeemable.

Down memory lane

Can a neighbourhood design its own future? This community in Chennai is giving it a shot



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As a young girl, Shreya Krishnan, an architect and urban designer, spent several after-school hours at her grandfather’s house in Pelathope, Mylapore. The house, with its quintessential ornate grilles and sturdy columns, is now more than 150 years old – an example of the neighbourhood’s everyday heritage.

Growing up, she noticed the gradual change in the character of the street that translates to ‘jackfruit grove’. The 50-to-100-year-old buildings in this road once full of lawyers fascinated her as a child. However, they began disappearing, making way for new construction. Witnessing Vedanta Desikar Swamy Street (as it is referred to today), experience this change, instilled in her a sense of urgency to preserve Pelathope’s heritage.

These concerns eventually led to the creation of Pelathope Urban Living Lab (PULL), a living lab where residents, Government representatives, and technical experts collaboratively address urban challenges. As part of this effort, Shreya’s organisations PULL and SKDO, in partnership with BeFantastic (a tech-art platform) and PLUS (Public Landscape and Urbanism Studio), will be hosting Namma Theru Our Design from August 7 to 9. “We want to create a vision for society across themes – ecology, mobility and access, culture

and heritage, and livability – covering issues ranging from water management and walkability to preserving everyday heritage and improving public spaces,” says Shreya, adding that the event aims to create a community-led vision for Pelathope over the next five to 10 years.

Over the three-day event, Pelathope will come alive with art, games and storytelling sessions. Kolam workshops, live mural painting, traditional games and hopscotch will take over the streets, while sketching sessions and history-based card games will help participants reconnect with the neighbourhood.

“Rather than merely solving problems, we are envisioning the future of the neighbourhood. Through these discussions, we hope to create a blueprint for what the community wants Pelathope to become,” she adds.

Looking ahead, Shreya hopes to see one pilot project emerge from the workshop within the next six to 12 months, with the community deciding which proposal to take forward through a community vote. For her, however, the ambition extends beyond Pelathope. She believes the model could inspire a broader shift in how neighbourhood planning is approached across India.

To register, email pelathopeurbanlivinglab@skdo.in or follow them on Instagram [@pelathope.urban.living.lab](https://www.instagram.com/pelathope.urban.living.lab)

Sanjana Ganesh
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Lately, my writing playlist is all Susantika. While tripping, tumbling, and traversing through a slate of this Tamil indie artiste, I’ve found myself giggling over the lyrics she chooses to place in certain crevices of her songs. There is the occasional rap battle between her alter-egos, lyrics about womanhood, and love ballads.

On other days, when the tide seems rough, there is ‘Iravu Kadandhu’, the artiste’s most recognisable song, about what it takes to get through the night.

Over the six years that she has made indie music, Susantika, who toggles between Chennai and Puducherry, has released 10 singles while lying low and appealing to a niche audience.

Late in July, Susantika released ‘Idhellaam Adhisayam’, filled with romance in this age of modern love. It begins with the line “*Dating na ennakennanu theriyadhu*” and then goes on, in wonderment, about what it means to be in love with her muse. The synth captivates through the two minutes it runs, making it easy to buy into the sway.

Having rarely spoken to the press while still being an active part of the music scene in the city, one wonders if the privacy is intentional. That is where our interview begins. “I am not camera shy or private. I do not think I know how to work this world of promotions. How does one crack the mainstream while still staying authentic – that’s what I need – I’ve been thinking about that for years now. But somewhere in that process it gets lost,” she says.

Susantika’s foray into independent music began in 2020. She began by posting covers on Instagram and quickly moved to writing her own one-minute numbers, as days overlapped one another during the thick of the pandemic.

“I would sing at school and church as a child. There was one particular church in Pondicherry, White Parish [Our Lady of Angels Church] near the beach,

I’ve got a feeling

Artiste Susantika’s Tamil music takes one on a journey through life’s everythings and nothings. There is space for fights with alter-egos, and to fall in love



What starts as a hum (Above) ‘Idhellaam Adhisayam’; and (right) Susantika. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Iravu Kadandhu’ on streaming platforms. Back then, I had little to no apprehensions,” she says.

With a laugh, Susantika adds that she thought she was the first in the State to write her own music and put it up online.

“Pondy did not have an indie music scene. Only after coming to Chennai did I realise that people like Siennor and Kaber were already here. My music did

help me connect with a lot of others in the space. That was rewarding,” she says.

Six years hence, everything including the texture of this artiste’s voice has changed but people keep wondering if she is going to make another ‘Iravu Kadandhu’.

“My skills, interests, and the way I sing, have all changed. Most importantly, the production of it all. Today, there are videos accompanying the music and I like visualising them.”

Earlier this year, Susantika also released *Roja Towers*, a short drama film on the lives of two women, the idea of growing up and a traumatic event that changes both their lives. The film that switches between lightness and intensity happens with little effort. There are portions where young girls steal a tube of fairness cream and apply it at school in an attempt to become ‘white’. There is also the idea of emulating older, cooler neighbours. “I’ve earned a bunch of friends who can all help me make films because they live and breathe cinema. I now enjoy the medium and cannot wait to make more,” she says.

Susantika adds that the indie scene is yet to be established in Tamil with only a few labels producing indie work (she released ‘Meimaranthen’ with Think Indie in 2025). She hopes for the medium to become more lucrative without insistence on a male-gaze based glamour, or rappers boasting about how great they are.

“In a day, a human experiences a thousand thoughts and as many feelings. Most however, do not pay as much heed to them. It is part of their life, part of their day,” she says, adding, “There are some of us who think of this feeling, ponder and write songs about the everythings and nothings. That is my pitch to you.”

Susantika has a number of originals lined up over the next few months. Follow her work on [@asusantika](https://www.instagram.com/asusantika) on Instagram.

Cities, coasts, novels

Journalist and author Akila Kannadasan’s *Sea Goddess* is rooted in years spent documenting Chennai’s fishing communities. “*Sea Goddess* is based on the many steely women I met along Chennai’s coast. They are all there in spirit,” she says. Akila will discuss the book at The Love Lit Society’s first author conversation on August 9, 11am at Vinyl & Brew, Alwarpet. Tickets priced at ₹825, at kynhood.



Looms and legacies

DakshinaChitra Museum invites visitors to celebrate Handloom Day with a series of events. On August 9, from 3pm to 6pm is Beyond the Loom: A Journey through South Indian Textiles, a curated heritage walk led by architect Shivani Sathesh. On

August 21, 2pm is Exploring Revival, a discussion with Naresh Subramaniam, Anita Soundar and Ravikumar. @DakshinaChitra Museum, Muttukadu. To register, call 9952894859.

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: Dass Community Hall No.55, Copalapuram, Opp. Hotel Chola Sheraton

Egmore

: Guild of Service, 18, Casa Major Road

Anna Nagar

: D. K. Mahal, W-114, 3rd Avenue, Near Roundtanna

Ambattur

: Arul Jothi Kalyana Mandapam, 162 A, Ambattur Redhills High Road, Near Rakki Cinemas

OMR Sholinganalur

: K.V.L Kalyana Mahal, 161, Opp. Accenture, Opp. Bharat Petroleum

Chromepet

: Ananda Thirumana Maligai, 220, G.S.T. Road, Near Lalithaa Jewellery Mart, Next to Morris Garages Showroom (Only this venue today is last day)



CHILD’S PLAY



Big dreams
Lithanya Sivabalan; with Vijay in *Jana Nayagan*. SHIVARAJ S



Jana Nayagan and beyond:
The rise of Vijay’s little co-star,
Lithanya Sivabalan

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“I’m a pro legend,” screams Lithanya, as I invite her to play a game of snakes and ladders. Sure enough, she rolls a six on the dice immediately – the number needed to determine who starts the game. She speeds through the squares. I struggle to even get started. Within a few turns, she has moved up two ladders and is swiftly making progress towards a successful finish. Watching her play, it is difficult not to notice the parallel. Much like racing through the board with confidence, she is steadily climbing the ladder of the Tamil entertainment world. Lithanya Sivabalan – or Lithu, as friends call her – is fast rising as one of the most sought-after child artistes. English homework awaits this Class III student of Vels Vidyashram, but for now, beating me in snakes and ladders is clearly

priority. At her residence in Nanmangalam, the terrace of which overlooks a lake, Lithu is basking in the attention she is receiving thanks to Vijay’s *Jana Nayagan*, her latest film that released on July 23. “It was an amazing experience acting with Vijay mama,” she tells me, “The whole shoot was jolly.” In the actor’s swansong, Lithanya features in the opening scenes as Viji, the child artiste who would grow up to become the girl played by Mamitha Baiju. Apart from sharing screenspace with Gautham Menon in these sequences, she also holds the distinction of being featured prominently in actor Vijay’s probable last outing as a singer – the melodious ‘Kanne Maniye’ track in *Jana Nayagan*. Unfortunately, Lithanya herself has not seen watched it yet; the film, starring the actor-turned-Chief Minister, was granted an ‘A’ certificate by the CBFC. “It is disheartening. But my parents watched the film and said that I have done a good job,” she says with a sigh, about the H Vinoth-directorial.

Having debuted with Tamil film *Siren* and explored Tamil TV serials with *Chellame Chellame*, Lithanya is already over a dozen projects old now. But her tryst with the camera started much earlier – actually when she was just 1.5 years old. Her mother – Sriguna – was dancing to a film tune at home, when little Lithanya joined her. “We sensed her passion for dance. As time passed, she even started asking, ‘Can I do like this?’ when she would see a reel. An actress (Radhishree) suggested we take her for an audition, and that’s how *Siren* happened,” says Sriguna, who has



On set, I love watching other actors get ready for their particular sequences. When I have a scene, my dialogues are given well in advance. I keep them in mind and act it out when they film

LITHANYA SIVABALAN
Child artiste

now quit her job to take care of her daughter’s commitments. Her happiest moment, admits Sriguna, arrived when the family received a call from director H Vinoth’s office, confirming that she was part of ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay’s swansong. “We were all jumping with joy. It was the most unforgettable phone call of our lives.” Her parents – Sivabalan and Sriguna – are particular that their girl doesn’t let the fame go to her head. Adds Sriguna, “We make sure she understands that acting is something she does, but it doesn’t define who she is. We keep reminding her that appreciation is lovely, but it should never make her feel that she is better than anyone else. For us, the goal is not just to see her become a successful actor, but to see her grow into a kind, grounded and happy person.” For now, Lithanya has her hands full with projects, key among them being Kavin’s *Per Sollum Pillai*, Vijay Antony’s *Appakutty* and a film titled *Irاندುವانம்*. Balancing busy shooting schedules and studies is priority, admits the eight-year-old who also likes playing badminton. “Whenever I miss school, my friends send me notes,” she says. When she grows up, she wants to become a “doctor, skateboarder and actor”. “An all-rounder,” she chimes, as we wrap up our intense game of snakes and ladders that she wins. And, just like that, she proves that she is – in her own words – a “pro legend”.



Child prodigy
Adhisheshan; (above) with his acting trainer Ajithlal Sivalal. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Meet Adhisheshan,
the boy wonder from
Balan: The Boy

Parshathy J Nath

The wide-eyed boy born in a prison, raised by criminals and a gritty mother under different identities, has left a lasting impression on Malayali film buffs. Seven-year-old Adhisheshan has impressed everyone with his screen presence and precision of expression in the recent Malayalam film *Balan: The Boy*, directed by Manjummel Boys maker, Chidambaram. When we get on a call with the child actor, endearingly called Pikku, he has just finished his tuition classes to make up for the ones he missed. A smile flashed across the boy’s face when he spotted Ajithlal Sivalal, his acting trainer, on the call. The trainer and his student are meeting after almost a year. “Adhisheshan had a delightful energy and presence about him,” recalls Ajithlal. Working with children requires a different approach, says Ajithlal, an actor and acting trainer in the Malayalam film industry. “We cannot use jargon as we do with the adult actors. So, we played games. And, we did a lot of singing, sometimes in gibberish or alien languages. But overall, the mood was playful. They might hate acting if we make it serious early on. Pikku was doing even serious scenes with a playful approach.” Ajithlal and Adhisheshan rolled up their sleeves to give us a glimpse into their rehearsal room fun. The exercise was for activating imagination. Ajithlal started his first prompt: “Adhi, there is a plate of hot fragrant biryani in front of you!” And Adhisheshan’s eyes instantly brighten up. And then Ajithlal says, “Ayye, it has some stench,” and the child’s brow furrows to enact doubt. And then Ajithlal goes on, “Oh, suddenly you hear a sound from the back. Is it a ghost?” Adhisheshan looks over his shoulder with a sharp turn. He does not anticipate; he is in the moment, just responding to the prompts. Adhisheshan was only five-and-a-half years old

when he went into training with Ajithlal. “The brief I got from the director’s team was to fix his gaze for the camera. And then I wanted to build his craft that would enable him to deliver the creative requirements of the filmmaker on set,” explains Ajithlal. He followed up on his exercises at home with the help of his mother in the next six months prior to shooting. By the time the filming began, Adhisheshan was ready to jump into the process with presence and spontaneity. His natural flair for truthful reactions comes through in the movie as well. The boy recalls being genuinely scared when Farzana Palathingal, the actor who plays his mother, took him by his collar to scold him in one of the

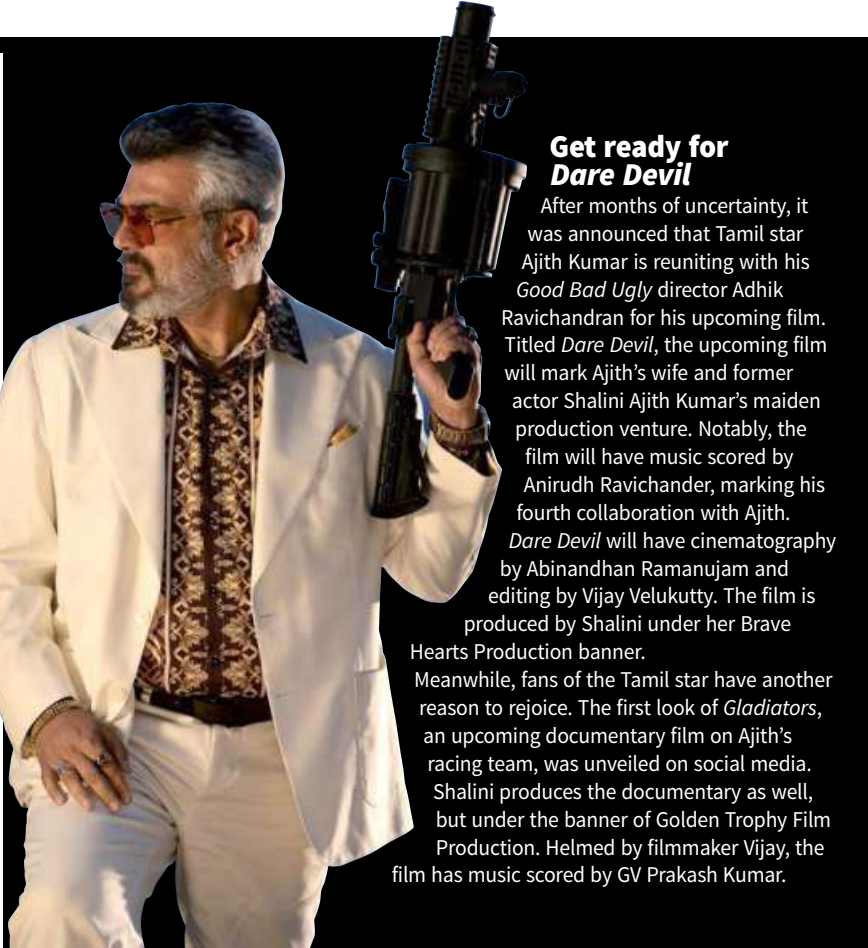


scenes. “Farzana *chechi* was very scary. It came as a surprise to me. I responded in a way I genuinely felt. The director also hadn’t briefed me about this scene prior to the shoot.” Creating a safe, gentle space for children is key to this process, adds Ajithlal. Stressing that their mental health is the priority, he says that when these child actors grow up, they must look back at these processes with joy. “We wanted to offer a nurturing ambience to make him comfortable enough to feel playful. For a few days, we were working in a home-like ambience, with his mother around him.” Suddenly, Adhisheshan, who had broken off the conversation to get back to his toys, pops up on our phone screens again. He shows us his Spider-Man toy collection. “All that I know about acting is from watching movies. I also watch some YouTube videos to see people act out expressions.” As for his favourite actors: “I love Tovino, Mohanlal, Mammooty and...”, looking at one of the toys endearingly, he adds, “Spider-Man!”

Balan: The Boy is currently streaming on ZEE5



Karthi, Mohan Raja get together
Tamil star Karthi has teamed up with director Mohan Raja for a family entertainer. The movie will be bankrolled by Prince Pictures, the banner that produced Karthi’s *Sardar*. Details regarding the technical crew and the rest of the cast are yet to be announced. Director Mohan Raja, celebrated for films such as *M. Kumaran Son of Mahalakshmi* (2004), *Santhosh Subramaniam* (2008), and *Thani Oruvan* (2015), is currently celebrating his 25th year in the film industry. His last directorial was the 2022 Chiranjeevi-starrer *Godfather*. Meanwhile, Karthi, last seen in *Vaa Vaathiyaar*, has *Sardar 2*, *Marshall*, and an untitled Tamil-Telugu project with director Kalyan Sundar in the pipeline.



Get ready for
Dare Devil

After months of uncertainty, it was announced that Tamil star Ajith Kumar is reuniting with his *Good Bad Ugly* director Adhik Ravichandran for his upcoming film. Titled *Dare Devil*, the upcoming film will mark Ajith’s wife and former actor Shalini Ajith Kumar’s maiden production venture. Notably, the film will have music scored by Anirudh Ravichander, marking his fourth collaboration with Ajith. *Dare Devil* will have cinematography by Abinandhan Ramanujam and editing by Vijay Velukutty. The film is produced by Shalini under her Brave Hearts Production banner. Meanwhile, fans of the Tamil star have another reason to rejoice. The first look of *Gladiators*, an upcoming documentary film on Ajith’s racing team, was unveiled on social media. Shalini produces the documentary as well, but under the banner of Golden Trophy Film Production. Helmed by filmmaker Vijay, the film has music scored by GV Prakash Kumar.

Scammer on the prowl

Nimrat Kaur and Roshan Mathew will be seen next in Prime Video’s survival drama series, *Job Trafficking*, the streamer announced this week. Directed by Prashant Nair, the show also stars Kavya Trehan, and Pavan Malhotra in pivotal roles. The eight-episode tells the story of industrialized online scams, commonly known as “pig butchering”, where perpetrators spend months building trust with their victims online before scamming them. As per a press release, “The series follows three strangers – a trapped scammer fighting to break free, a defrauded housewife seeking answers, and a CEO caught in the crossfire – whose paths collide in a dangerous web of fractured trust, deception, and exploitation. What begins as a dream of opportunity spirals into a nightmare of captivity and coercion.”



Who is Dorothy?

Ace Tamil filmmaker Karthik Subbaraj has revealed the title of his upcoming movie. The *Petta* director took to social media to announce that his 10th directorial is *Dorothy*. *Dorothy* will star Keerthy Suresh, Sananth, and Rishikanth in lead roles. The movie will be premiering at the Toronto International Film Festival. Ilaiyaraaja has composed the music. “From growing up with his music to working with him feels special,” Karthik had said after teaming up with Ilaiyaraaja. *Dorothy*, scheduled to hit screens on September 25, has been bankrolled by Sikhya Entertainment in association with Jio Studios and Karthik Subbaraj’s Dhammam Films. “A story that is very close to my heart and a film I wanted to make for many years is finally made,” wrote Karthik on X.